



Training beast: Virat's unmatched intensity at training — dozens of catches, endless run-outs — made his match-day brilliance feel routine.

K.R. DEEPAK

emerge with heads held high.

Of the centuries he has scored in Australia, I am fascinated by the one in Perth in 2018. It was a fast track with the ball flying around, but he tore into the bowlers even as most other batsmen looked ordinary on that pitch. Tendulkar also hit a century in Perth in 1992, but then the conditions were so different.

I am sure Virat still had two years of Test cricket left in him. I would have loved to see him in England this summer. It would have been a good idea to hand him the captaincy for the tour, but he would know best why he decided to leave. Maybe mental fatigue drove him to

decide because he was as fit as any other player in the team.

He knew his body best, but the mind would have played the decisive role. I will not rule out burnout as the decisive factor in curtailing his career at a critical phase of Indian cricket.

For me, Virat will remain the most influential cricketer of the last decade. He had fans worldwide, especially those who turned up at Test matches to watch him bat like no one else. A batsman who could hit a boundary at will and someone who would pick the best bowler in the opposition camp to send a strong message.

Undoubtedly the most scrutinised batsman in world cricket, he was also the best prepared to fight in the middle. His making people watch Test cricket will be an enduring legacy. The team will forever miss his wild celebrations at

the fall of a wicket and the joy he expressed at a partner's batting feat.

He is still around to serve Indian cricket in ODIs, but I also know that Virat will walk away from the game once he is done playing cricket. He is not the kind who would like to coach or take on the role of a broadcaster. I will miss him when India plays its first Test in England. He was a champion, and that is what I would like to remember — never conceding an inch.

As told to Vijay Lokapally

[Ravi Shastri served as India's head coach from 2017 to 2021 — a period that coincided with Virat Kohli's captaincy across formats. Together, they delivered India's first Test series win in 71 years in Australia, dominated bilateral white-ball cricket, and guided India to the 2019 ODI World Cup semifinal.]